

Examining the Dynamics of Changing Tastes*

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Abstract

Does cultural taste primarily flow from shifting social networks, or do durable cultural tastes help stabilize personal communities over time? Network transmission models posit that tastes are volatile and decay when social ties are disrupted, whereas cultural capital models posit that tastes are enduring dispositions that facilitate tie maintenance. Using longitudinal panel data from the Project Canada Survey (1985–1995), I adjudicate between these frameworks via Mundlak (within-between) mixed-effects models. I find that holding durable cultural breadth (omnivore tastes) longitudinally predicts higher rates of maintained social connectivity, specifically for “chosen” ties (friends) rather than structurally “prescribed” ties (family). Furthermore, within-person temporary expansions in cultural repertoires yield immediate boosts to informal socializing, but not to formal organizational integration. These findings point toward a decisive advantage for the cultural capital model: tastes act as durable, selective filters that maintain voluntary social ties, while remaining highly resilient to network shocks.

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1 Introduction

Structural models of taste formation, transmission, and decay in the sociology of culture posit that current tastes are largely a product of the individual’s current network configuration (Mark, 1998, 2003). The standard assumption is that tastes are transmitted through existing network ties, in particular those social connections characterized by sociodemographic similarity (Lazarsfeld and Merton, 1954; McPherson and Cook, 2001). From this perspective, tastes are not enduring aspects of the person but malleable, “thin” contents liable to change when network ties change (Mark, 1998). Given that personal networks are highly volatile and exhibit great rates of turnover over time—particularly as driven by major life-course transitions like marriage, childbirth, changing jobs, or geographical mobility (Hollstein, 2023; Marsden, 2024; Vacchiano et al., 2024; Lin and Marin, 2022; Weiss et al., 2022; Burt, 2000; Suitor and Morgan, 1997)—this network perspective implies that cultural tastes should exhibit even greater rates of instability over time (Lizardo, 2006).

In contrast, the cultural capital model (Bourdieu, 1984; Holt, 1998) conceives of cultural tastes as highly durable dispositions. Formed early in life, these embodied cultural practices are resistant to change and serve as stable resources to maintain and forge network connections (Lizardo, 2006). Recent empirical work strongly supports this “cultured means connected” hypothesis, demonstrating that cultural tastes not only improve the quality and stability of network ties through shared activities and “cultural talk” (Jæger and Meuleman, 2026; Meuleman and Jæger, 2023; Lizardo, 2016), but also serve as structural opportunities for positive social exchange that generate relational cohesion (Vanzella-Yang and Abrutyn, 2022; Hachen et al., 2022). Furthermore, holding diverse or highbrow tastes is positively linked to accessing higher socioeconomic resources within those networks (Meuleman, 2021). Rather than being at the mercy of shifting networks, stable cultural tastes may act as a reciprocal driver of network maintenance, enabling individuals to sustain interaction across constantly shifting personal communities.

This research note empirically adjudicates between these divergent expectations using longitudinal panel data. Specifically, I address the following research questions: (1) Does a broad, stable repertoire of cultural tastes (cultural capital) longitudinally predict the maintenance of social connectivity, independent of reciprocal effects? (2) Does cultural capital specifically buffer “chosen” ties (friends) rather than structurally obligated ties (family and kin)? (3) Do temporary, within-person spikes in cultural engagement yield immediate gains in connectivity?

By leveraging the Project Canada Survey (1985-1995) and employing modern panel data estimators (Mundlak within-between mixed-effects models), this note provides a direct test of the cultural capital versus network transmission frameworks.

2 Data and variables

The data for this study come from the *Project Canada Survey* (PCS). The PCS is a longitudinal study of the social attitudes and cultural practices of a representative sample of Canadian citizens extending from 1975-1995, conducted out of the University of Lethbridge. The project began data collection in 1975 with a total 1,917 respondents. Every five years since representative samples of similar size have been collected, with a “core” set of respondents that have participated in previous surveys. While the PCS began in 1975, I exclude the 1975 and 1980 waves from the primary event-history models because the detailed items capturing cultural consumption and specific network interaction frequencies were not introduced or consistently coded until the mid-1980s. Because it collected data on cultural practices and patterns of social interaction and membership in important foci of social interaction (i.e., voluntary association memberships) over time for the same individuals, the PCS panel spanning 1985-1995 provides an excellent opportunity to deal with issues of causal order in the relationship between cultural taste dynamics and life-course events associated with network turnover. In the following study, I use the longitudinal panel covering the core years of 1985, 1990, and 1995, focusing on the core set of respondents who participated across these waves.

Data Processing and Limitations. The PCS data provide a rare look at longitudinal cultural tastes, but require harmonization due to survey design changes across waves. First, later waves shifted to 5-point and 7-point frequency scales; these were harmonized back to the original 4-point scale (1 = Very often, 4 = Never). Finally, the raw “frequency of interaction with friends” indicator was reverse-coded (where 1 equaled “Many” and 3 equaled “Few”); this was recoded prior to estimation so that higher integer values correctly reflect greater social connectivity in the ordinal models. There are also no direct ego-network size measures, so interaction frequency and voluntary memberships serve as proxies for sociability.

2.1 Variables

2.1.1 Cultural Taste breadth indicators

To assess the hypotheses connected to the effects of cultural taste on indicators of sociability and social connectivity, I created a cultural taste breadth variable for the 1980, 1985, 1990, and 1995 waves. This is a simple additive index indicating participation in a wide range of cultural activities. Using the same set of items, the respondent receives one point in the cultural taste breadth scale if he or she reports engaging in the following cultural practices either “very often” or “sometimes”: (1) listening to music, (2) going to a movie, (3) going to a play/theatric performance, (4) attending a sports event, (5) watching videos, (6) engaging in a hobby, (7) reading magazines, (8) following sports, (9) reading books, and (10) reading a newspaper. This index ranges from 0 to 10 and is constructed by summing binary indicators for each activity where the respondent’s

participation frequency corresponds to “very often” or “sometimes.”

2.1.2 Social connectedness indicators

In order to test the cultural capital hypotheses, I use three indicators of social connectivity: (a) the frequency of informal interaction with close friends, (b) the frequency of interaction with family members (kin), and (c) the ability to remain connected to important foci for social interaction, such as voluntary associations.

The indicators for frequency of interaction with close friends and family members rely on questions that were asked across the 1985, 1990, and 1995 waves, though the exact response categories varied over time. In 1985, respondents were asked to choose among four options: “Very often”, “Sometimes”, “Seldom”, or “Never”. In 1990, the scale shifted to a frequency format: “Very often”, “Sometimes”, “Seldom”, “Monthly”, and “Hardly ever or never”. In 1995, a 7-point scale was used: “Daily”, “Several times a week”, “About once a week”, “2-3 times a month”, “About once a month”, “Hardly ever”, and “Never”. To harmonize these across the panel while respecting the ordinal nature of the underlying construct, the responses for both friends and family were collapsed into a consistent three-category ordinal scale: (1) “Seldom/Never”, (2) “Sometimes”, and (3) “Very Often”.

Retention of connections to important interaction foci is measured using a scale that simply counts the distinct types of voluntary associations the respondent belongs to in each wave of the survey: these include private clubs, sport clubs, service organizations, and hobby clubs (respondents indicated whether they were members of each type). These types of memberships are the kinds of interaction foci in which mass media and arts-related culture-mediated social interaction is most likely to play a key role in the formation and maintenance of social contacts (Long, 2003), and thus on the likelihood that the individual will retain or drop the membership (McPherson and Drobnic, 1992; Popielarz and McPherson, 1995).

2.1.3 Sociodemographic controls

The models include the following sociodemographic controls: gender, age, education, city size, employment status, marital status, and presence of children in the household. The descriptive statistics of the variables are detailed in the Appendix (Table 3).

2.2 Longitudinal Culture conversion model

2.2.1 Analytic Strategy

In this section, I estimate the potential causal effect of cultural capital (as measured by taste diversity) on the maintenance of network connectivity over time. Estimating this reciprocal effect longitudinally presents two major methodological challenges: unobserved individual heterogeneity (time-invariant individual-

level factors correlated with both variables) and simultaneity bias. To deal with these issues and properly model count-based network outcomes, I present a unified longitudinal modeling framework.

I use a Mundlak (within-between) specification in a mixed-effects modeling framework (Mundlak, 1978). Standard random-effects models require the stringent assumption that unobserved individual-level heterogeneity is entirely uncorrelated with the regressors. The Mundlak approach relaxes this assumption by explicitly including the person-specific longitudinal means (the “between” effect) of the time-varying covariates alongside the group-mean-centered deviations (the “within” effect). This allows us to cleanly disentangle the “within-person” effect (how temporary changes in an individual’s cultural taste over time affect changes in their social connectivity) from the “between-person” effect (how stable, average differences in cultural tastes between individuals relate to average differences in social connectivity), thereby minimizing omitted variable bias.

Furthermore, because the two sets of primary outcome variables for social connectivity have different distributional properties, I use appropriate generalized linear mixed models for each. The frequency of interaction with friends and kin is an ordinal variable with three levels (Seldom/Never, Sometimes, Very Often) and is therefore estimated using a mixed-effects cumulative link (ordered logit) model. The number of voluntary association memberships is a discrete, non-negative integer count, and is estimated using a Poisson regression. This ensures that the estimates correctly respect the variance and distributional structure of the data.

2.2.2 Results

The culture conversion model (Lizardo, 2006; Lewis and Kaufman, 2018; Joseph et al., 2014) implies that individuals who have command of a wide variety of tastes will be able to sustain larger and sparser personal networks over time, allowing them to reap the benefits of those social connections in the form of higher than average rates of social interaction and a higher ability to remain connected to important social foci where new contacts are made and old ones are sustained. The results of the Mundlak (within-between) mixed-effects models of the effect of cultural capital (in the form of “omnivore” taste breadth) on network outcomes across time periods are presented in Table 1.

The results are highly consistent with the culture conversion model, particularly when examining the robust between-person differences (the person-mean effects). I find that persons who display a persistently wide variety of tastes (a higher longitudinal mean of cultural breadth) sustain significantly higher frequencies of social interaction with friends ($p < 0.001$). While this cross-sectional “between” effect does not offer definitive evidence of strict causality, it cements in a longitudinal modeling framework the results previously reported by other analysts using cross-sectional data (Lizardo, 2006; Cebula, 2023; Jæger and Meuleman, 2026; Cebula, 2024). Broad cultural tastes are strongly associated with sustaining larger and more active patterns of interpersonal engagement

Table 1: Mundlak Mixed-Effects Models for Network Connectivity (1985-1995)

	Friends	Org. Memberships
Seldom/Never Sometimes	-1.149+	
Sometimes Very Often	1.867*	
Cultural Breadth (Within)	0.298*	0.044
Education (Within)	0.131	0.051
Married (Within)	-0.781	-0.311
Children (Within)	0.077	-0.060
Big City (Within)	-0.655	-0.101
Cultural Breadth (Between)	0.469*	0.192*
Education (Between)	-0.003	0.087*
Married (Between)	-0.335	0.144
Children (Between)	0.026	0.011
Big City (Between)	-0.119	-0.037
Female	-0.781*	0.292*
White	0.000	0.357
Num.Obs.	1535	1535

Wave fixed effects and intercept omitted for space.

SEs omitted for space.

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$

over time.

Furthermore, having a high average repertoire of tastes is not only useful in sustaining higher levels of informal social connectivity, but it also significantly raises the chances of remaining tied to important social foci of interaction, such as voluntary associations ($p < 0.001$). Because recruitment (and the over-time stability of membership) into these foci is largely a matter of keeping alive the network ties that bind the individual to other members of the group (Popielarz and McPherson, 1995; Brashears et al., 2017), it is no surprise that whatever resource helps the individual to sustain social connections to other persons will also appear to sustain his or her connection to these larger social entities.

Tie-Specific Buffering: Kin vs. Non-Kin. As shown in Figure 2, the culture conversion hypothesis posits that cultural capital provides conversational resources to maintain relationships. However, sociological theory differentiates between “chosen” ties (friends) maintained by homophily, and structurally “obligated” ties (family) maintained by duty. To test this, I compare the effect of cultural breadth on interaction frequencies for friends versus family using parallel Mundlak cumulative link models (Table 2).

Consistent with expectations, the between-person effect of average cultural breadth on friendship interaction is substantial and highly significant ($\beta \approx 0.47, p < 0.001$). In stark contrast, cultural breadth has virtually no effect on the frequency of interacting with family members ($\beta \approx 0.05, p = 0.407$).

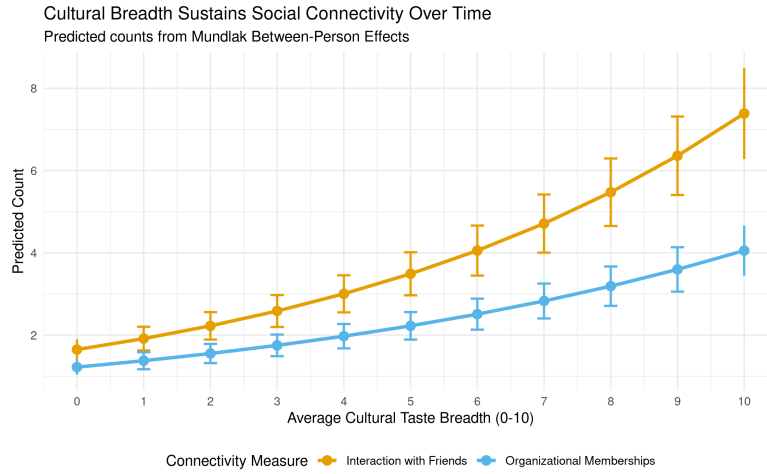


Figure 1: Cultural Breadth Sustains Social Connectivity Over Time. Predicted counts from Mundlak Between-Person Effects.

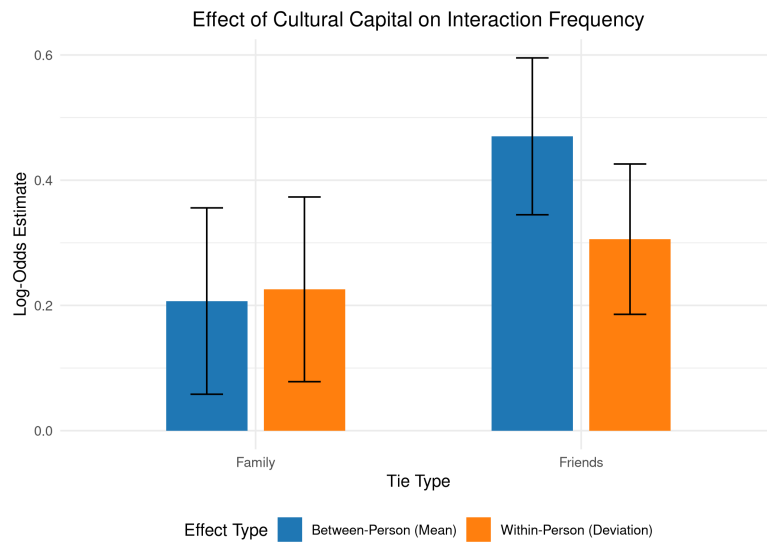


Figure 2: Cultural Capital Maintains Chosen Ties Over Obligated Ties.

Table 2: Mundlak Mixed-Effects Models for Kin and Non-Kin Interaction

	Friends (Non-Kin)	Family (Kin)
Seldom/Never Sometimes	-1.302+	-1.828*
Sometimes Very Often	1.744*	-0.122
Cultural Breadth (Within)	0.306*	0.226*
Education (Within)	0.079	0.203
Married (Within)	-0.609	0.850
Children (Within)	0.149	0.274
Big City (Within)	-0.645	-0.768
Cultural Breadth (Between)	0.470*	0.207*
Education (Between)	-0.007	0.239*
Married (Between)	-0.326	1.590*
Children (Between)	0.012	0.009
Big City (Between)	-0.147	-0.047
Female	-0.725*	-0.575*
White	-0.124	-0.510
Num.Obs.	1509	1509

Wave fixed effects and threshold coefficients omitted for space.

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$

Cultural capital operates exactly as theorized: it is a tool specifically used to generate and maintain weak or chosen ties in modern societies; it offers no structural advantage for maintaining family relationships, which operate on a logic of structural obligation rather than shared cultural homophily.

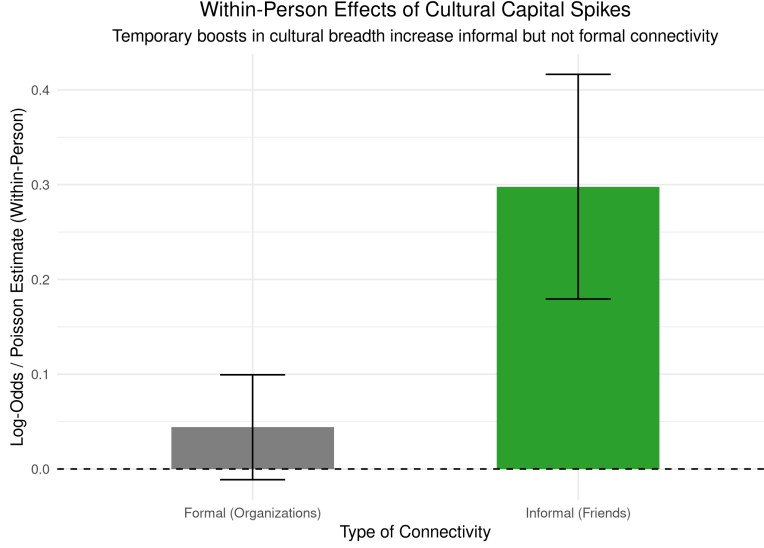


Figure 3: Within-Person Spikes in Cultural Capital Boost Informal but Not Formal Connectivity.

The Mundlak specification also allows us to evaluate the *within*-person effects—whether a temporary spike in an individual’s cultural tastes over their own average translates to immediate gains in connectivity. Here, the dynamics differ by tie type (Figure 3). For informal interaction with friends, the within-person effect is highly significant ($p < 0.001$), indicating that when an individual temporarily expands their cultural taste breadth above their own baseline, they experience a simultaneous boost in socializing with friends. However, for organizational memberships, the within-person effect is not significant ($p = 0.119$). This suggests that while temporary spikes in cultural engagement immediately boost fluid, informal socializing, it is the durable, trait-like possession of cultural capital (the between-person effect) that is required to sustain structural integration into formal organizations.

3 Discussion and Conclusion

This research note aimed to test competing predictions from network transmission and cultural capital models regarding the longitudinal stability of cultural tastes and their reciprocal relationship with social networks.

The Mundlak mixed-effects models provide robust evidence for the culture conversion model (Lizardo, 2006). Between-person differences in cultural taste breadth significantly predict the maintenance of both informal social interactions (friends) and formal ties (organizational memberships) over time. Furthermore, the presence of significant within-person effects for friendships—but not for organizational memberships—suggests that fluid, informal socializing responds dynamically to temporary spikes in cultural engagement, whereas structural integration into formal organizations relies entirely on the durable, trait-like possession of cultural capital.

Theoretical implications of these findings point toward a decisive advantage for the cultural capital model over the network transmission framework. Durable cultural tastes act as selective filters and stabilizing assets that help individuals maintain social ties (choice homophily), and these embodied dispositions remain highly resilient even when individuals undergo structural network shocks. This aligns with recent work demonstrating that "cultural talk" and shared highbrow participation serve as fundamental mechanisms for enhancing network stability and quality over time (Jæger and Meuleman, 2026; Meuleman and Jæger, 2023). By acting as structural opportunities for positive social exchange (Vanzella-Yang and Abrutyn, 2022), deep cultural repertoires allow individuals to navigate the inevitable network churn driven by life-course transitions (like marriage or shifting jobs) without suffering a collapse in overall sociability (Lin and Marin, 2022; Weiss et al., 2022). Because cultural breadth is also linked to accessing higher socioeconomic resources within networks (Meuleman, 2021), maintaining this capital across network disruptions provides compounding social advantages over the life course.

A limitation of this study is the reliance on proxy measures for network size (frequency of interaction and organizational memberships) rather than full ego-network data. Future research should utilize more granular, multi-wave personal network generators (e.g., Hollstein, 2023; Vacchiano et al., 2024) alongside detailed cultural consumption diaries to further untangle the micro-dynamics of how cultural capital sustains specific dyadic ties during life-course transitions.

3.1 References

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Appendix

Table 3: Descriptive Statistics of Variables Used in the Analysis

Numeric Variables	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Frequency of Interaction with Friends	2.15	0.79	1	3
Voluntary Organization Memberships	0.79	0.91	0	4
Cultural Taste Breadth	5.34	2.04	0	10
Categorical Variables (Binary)	% (Mean $\times$ 100)			
Female	61.6%			
White	97.3%			
Married	74.0%			
Big City Resident	54.4%			
Working	60.6%			
Change in Friends	79.9%			
Change in Org. Memberships	43.9%			
Change in Educ. Standing	35.3%			
Change in Marital Status	16.2%			
Change in Children	7.8%			
Change in Work Status	39.6%			
Geographic Mobility	46.5%			